crucial because this was a very prosperous region. It was, in fact, reputed to be part of one of the richest provinces in the ancient East from a time preceding Alexander's arrival in 326 BCE: the twentieth satrapy of the Achaemenid empire in the sixth century BCE had been described by Herodotus as the richest in the Persian empire.[13] The king of Taxila capitulated to Alexander, who is said to have sacrificed there as well as held 'a competition in athletics and horsemanship'.[14] Subsequently, Alexander marched eastward to attack Porus, leaving behind at Taxila—as he did in various other conquered cities—a garrison of Macedonians and mercenaries under a commander. The mercenaries murdered their commander, but they too did not last long. Towards the end of the fourth century BCE Taxila was again subjugated, this time by Chandragupta.

Martial conquests such as those by Alexander and Chandragupta, as by other heroic men of the past, have been endowed with celebrity status because military success and the building of vast empires—which from a saner perspective might justifiably be thought of as male megalomania of the most revolting form—have come to be accepted as 'wonderful' and 'great'. Looked at from a more Ashokan lens, i.e. a moral common sense based on humanity, compassion, and fellow feeling, these men of drive and ambition slaughtered thousands of soldiers, divested Taxila of its independent political status, and ruined the lives of the city's residents and their families. The *Ashokavadana*'s account of a restive populace, resentful of the Mauryan ministers who oppressed them, if historically true, makes eminent sense. And Ashoka is likely to have been a relieved man if indeed its citizens, contrary to his expectations, welcomed rather than resisted him.

What did Taxila look like when it welcomed him? Literary accounts are unsatisfactorily silent about this. John Marshall, who devoted twenty-two years of his working life to excavating Taxila, writes of the curiosity of the Greeks accompanying Alexander when they saw the city's shaven-headed and long-haired ascetics, whom they encountered practising austerities. The